

Words and music

The voice is music's natural instrument. Fusing words and music is one of humankind's oldest and most important pastimes.

SEE ALSO

◀ 24–25 Beats and measures

◀ 192–193 Voices

The Baroque period 208–209 ▶

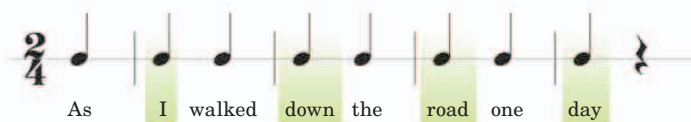
The Romantic period 212–213 ▶

Meter

The natural rhythm of words is called meter. When setting text, composers generally aim to observe its natural meter. By elaborating selected words or phrases with extra notes or shifting the stress on certain words, sections of the text can be highlighted for the listener.

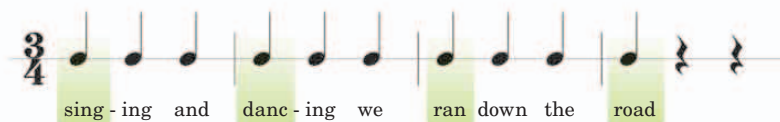
▷ “As I walked down the road one day...”

Here the natural stress of the words suggests a two-beats-in-a-bar or duple rhythm.



▷ “Singing and dancing we ran down the road...”

In this example, the natural stress of the words suggests a three-beats-in-a-bar or triple rhythm.

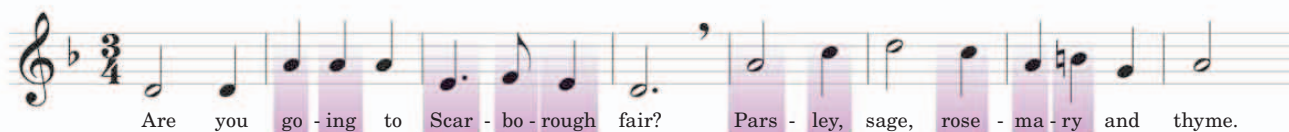


Syllabic setting

When a melody has exactly one note matched to each syllable it is called syllabic. A clear and simple approach, it works well for traditional folk songs and some hymns, when it is important that all the words are clearly heard.

▽ “Scarborough fair”

It is important that the listener can easily follow the words of this traditional folk song, so its simple tune and straightforward syllabic setting work well.



Melismatic setting

A melisma is a group of notes sung to one syllable. It produces a very expressive musical effect, and is used to draw special attention to a word or phrase. It has been used as a technique from earliest times in church music right up to contemporary pop music.

▽ Mozart's *Requiem*

The “Dona nobis pacem” (Give us peace) section from Mozart's *Requiem* features melismatic settings in each voice in turn. Shown here is an extract in the tenor voice.

